ENCAMPMENT AS A SITE OF GENDERED TRANSFORMATION: CASE STUDIES FROM TANZANIA, CZECHIA AND BANGLADESH

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QUESTION: HOW ARE GENDERED SUBJECTIVITIES AFFECTED IN ENCAMPMENT? DISCUSS USING CONCRETE EXAMPLES.

List of Abbreviations

Abbreviation	Meaning
NGOs	non-governmental organisations

Introduction

In the post-colonial global order, forced migration has become a commonplace occurrence, particularly affecting those states that were once colonially exploited and have since struggled to find a footing in stable governance. According to Katarzyna Grabska, a social anthropologist and senior researcher at the Peace Research Institute Oslo, 'forced migration…results in dramatic changes in the daily lives of all actors' (Grabska, 2011, cited in Çarpar and Yaylaci, 2021, p.3848). Thus, in documenting the experiences of individual refugees experiencing forced migration, researchers can come to understand the ways in which forced migration changes both refugees' physical and social realities. One of the most salient social constructions altered through the process of forced migration is the performance and conceptualisation of gender among refugees, or gendered subjectivities.

Refugee camps remain one of the most accessible places for researchers to investigate how gendered subjectivities are affected by the process of forced migration. They are, according to feminist ethnographic researcher Farhana Rahman, 'a microcosm of a larger system of power intertwined with gender, race, and class, as well as other systems of social inequality and subjugation' (Rahman, 2024, p.14). Refugee camps are spaces in which one can observe the metamorphoses of numerous social constructions — including race, gender, ethnicity, religion and family units — among the refugee population. These metamorphoses occur both because the refugee population has undergone dramatic changes to their lives and due to interactions between refugees that occur solely within the context of encampment (*e.g.,* between refugees from different countries of origin). Under these circumstances, refugees exercise their agency to 'reorient their environment by adapting new meanings and, ultimately, a renewed sense of self' (Rahman, 2024, p.48). The refugee camp thus acts as a laboratory for social change, including for changes in gendered subjectivities.

In this paper, I discuss several occurrences in which gendered subjectivities among refugee populations have transformed through the process of encampment. I begin by discussing how understandings and performances of masculinity have evolved among Burundian refugees in Tanzania. I then focus on feminine subjectivities, analysing changes to femininity among Chechen refugees. I finish with a discussion around how, in the context of encampment, refugees' responses to NGO provisions can themselves drive changes to gendered subjectivities among the refugee population.

Encampment and Masculinities

The experience of encampment provides refugee men with the opportunity to renegotiate their conceptualisations of masculinity. The phenomenon of masculine subjectivities being transformed through the interactions men have during encampment is exemplified by a several case studies, including that of Burundian refugees in Tanzania.

Becoming 'Like the Rwandans': New Masculinities for Burundian Refugees

In the Burundian culture, strict roles are assigned to men which dictate what behaviours constitute being a 'good' husband and a 'good' man. According to an ethnographic study conducted by Danish Institute for International Studies senior researcher Simon Turner in

Tanzanian refugee camps, 'good' Burundian husbands are 'expected to provide for' their families (Turner, 1999, p.4). Husbands exemplify this behaviour in the Burundian culture by, for example, 'giving nice clothes' to their wives (Turner, 1999, p.4), or by giving 'gifts' to their wives and children (Turner, 1999, pp.3-4). Burundian men give 'the orders in the house', acting as the primary decision-makers within the family unit (Turner, 1999, pp.3-4). Further, a 'good' Burundian husband or father is characterised as someone who takes 'the right decisions for the family's well-being as a whole', emphasising that a 'good' Burundian man is characterised by selflessness and pragmatism (Turner, 1999, pp.3-4). While serving as leading figures within a family unit, Turner claims that Burundian refugees would be quick to explain that such a leadership role 'does not mean that' the man 'is allowed to treat his wife badly' (Turner, 1999, pp.3-4). Accordingly, a good Burundian man is defined by his selflessness, care and equanimity.

According to the Burundian refugee men encountered in Turner's study, it is Burundian 'men's failure to be a real man and provide for his wife' that 'leads women failing to act as [they] ought to' (Turner, 1999, p.4). According to Burundian men, women should 'obey' their husbands, and it is due to their lack of respect, stemming from men's failures, that leads to women's disobedient behaviour (Turner, 1999, p.4). Turner recorded that, recurringly, Burundian men lamented 'that…women no longer respect them', and that this lack of respect stemmed from the men's inability to 'provide for their wives and children' (Turner, 1999, p.2). It is therefore clear that, for Burundian refugee men, the primary masculine behaviour is providing for one's family.

In the context of encampment in Tanzanian refugee camps, men's ability to perform masculinity as they feel they ought to is radically disrupted. Burundian men are unable 'to maintain the illusion of their superiority' due to the physical structure of Tanzanian refugee camps (Turner, 1999, p.5; Kleist, 2010, cited in Çarpar and Yaylaci, 2021, p.3855). Fathers and husbands in refugee camps are unable to control 'cash incomes' and buy 'a nice *kanga*[1] for' their wives, disrupting their ability to be, in their understandings, properly masculine (Turner, 1999, p.5). Furthermore, men's traditional 'knowledge and experience of local [Burundian] history, customs and families is of no use in' Tanzanian refugee camps (Turner, 1999, p.5). Burundian men's responses to disruptions to their 'masculine' faculties during encampment informs the construction of new masculine identities.

Through the refugee camp's disruption of Burundian men's masculine performances, opportunities opened for Burundian masculine subjectivities to be renegotiated. For instance, whereas deference to *mzungu*[2] was seen as a respectful, masculine action prior to encampment, Burundian men — young men in particular — were 'no longer shy to approach a *muzungu* [*sic*] or to say their opinion in a meeting' (Turner, 1999, p.9). These men explained that 'they had learned in the camp not to be "shy"' (Turner, 1999, p.9). Hence, what was once seen as immature behaviour became understood as masculine through the encampment process. Being outspoken became associated with 'manliness' itself through the context of encampment.

Men's inability to perform traditionally masculine roles was not the only influencing factor in the modification of Burundian masculine subjectivities during encampment in Tanzania. Interactions and association with both the 'host' culture and refugees of non-Burundian origin

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[1] A *kanga* is a traditional garment worn by East African women, characterised by its brightly coloured and printed cotton fabric.
[2] A *mzungu* is a white person, or a person of European descent.

in the Tanzanian camp also shaped masculine subjectivities for Burundians. For example, 'after spending some time with Rwandans in the camps', Burundian refugees claimed to be 'learning to be assertive like the Rwandans' (Turner, 1999, p.9). Like the former instance of Burundian men shedding their shyness, their interactions with Rwandan men and observances of Rwandan masculine subjectivities affected their own performances of masculinity; Burundian men actively decided to adopt an assertive nature, acknowledging the Rwandan origin of the new behaviour.

The ethnographic study of Burundian men in Tanzanian refugee camps exemplifies the evolution of masculine subjectivities through the process of encampment. Whereas prior to their encampment experiences, Burundian refugee men considered obsequiousness to be masculine in nature, through their interactions with Rwandans and their inability to rely on traditionally masculine behavioural indicators to express their masculinity, Burundian men came to understand assertiveness as masculine. Other ethnographies indeed confirm the changing power of encampment on the character of masculine subjectivities.

Encampment and Femininities

Consistent with the experiences of refugee men, the experience of encampment provides refugee women with the opportunity to renegotiate their conceptualisations of femininity. Much recent scholarship has explored this phenomenon, as women's stories often go ignored in the patriarchal 'microcosm' of the refugee camp (Rahman, 2024, p.14). Certain cases exemplify the phenomenon whereby refugee camp constraints shift feminine subjectivities, including that of Chechen refugee women in the Czech Republic.

Forced Adaptation: Transforming Chechen Women's Roles in Czech Camps

Within the Chechen culture, proper performances of femininity are primarily characterised by being good mothers and wives (Szczepaniková, 2005, p.290). The 'ideal' of femininity in Chechen culture is consequently one of 'domesticity', not dissimilar to ideals of femininity found in other central Asian cultures (Szczepaniková, 2005, p.291). However, the process of forced migration and encampment necessarily altered the (adaptive) hierarchy of gendered roles for Chechen women.

In Czech refugee camps, work was 'offered almost exclusively to women', who were seen by the camp organisers as 'more reliable and docile than men' (Szczepaniková, 2005, p.286). Correspondingly, in order 'to provide for their' families 'needs', Chechen women had 'to work and earn money' (Szczepaniková, 2005, p.289). This reality within Czech refugee camps displaced being a good wife and a good mother from the top of Chechen women's hierarchy of gendered roles, replacing those roles with that of a breadwinner, one traditionally occupied by men in the Chechen culture. While such work opportunities gave 'women the opportunity to become…sole breadwinners for their families', the expectations placed on Chechen women by Czech camp organisers perpetuated harmful male gender stereotypes and placed further pressure onto Chechen women to conform to Czech notions of femininity (Szczepaniková, 2005, p.286). Beyond occupying their newfound roles as breadwinners within the Czech refugee camp, Chechen women were 'often the only ones allowed to rescue their sons, husbands and brothers from the hands of soldiers' by Czech camp organisers (Szczepaniková, 2005, p.289). Accordingly, Chechen women displaced yet another role typically assigned to men in Chechen culture: the rescuer.

The displacement of men in roles typically understood to be masculine by Chechen women resulted in an increase in domestic violence among the refugee population (Szczepaniková,

2005, p.294). Chechen men found it incredibly 'difficult' to 'accept' women's increased power in the family unit, reacted with violence and placed further pressure upon Chechen women to conform to different conceptualisations of femininity simultaneously (Szczepaniková, 2005, p.294). While feminine subjectivities were doubtless 'challenged by the violent disruption of Chechen society', traditional Chechen feminine ideals remained (Szczepaniková, 2005, p.291). Accordingly, while Chechen women occupied traditionally masculine roles throughout encampment due to social realities in the refugee camp, they were placed under immense pressure and shame by Chechen men for failing to simultaneously embody traditional 'ideal[s]' of femininity (Szczepaniková, 2005, p.291). The pressure from multiple directions changed Chechen feminine subjectivities by blending the expectations of Czechs and Chechens with the realities Chechen women faced. While Chechen women came to understand providing 'for their families' as a collective and feminine struggle within the camp, they also 'tolerated' men's behaviour towards them, respecting traditional Chechen notions of marriage as an honour- and respect-providing institution (Szczepaniková, 2005, p.289).

The process of encampment in the Czech Republic forced upon Chechen women new notions of femininity, altering their feminine subjectivities. Whereas prior to encampment, Chechen femininity was characterised by being a good wife and a good mother, and more generally by embodying domesticity, the process of encampment forced Chechen women into the roles of the primary breadwinner and the family rescuer, all while being simultaneously pressured by the expectations of Czech camp organisers that they would be 'reliable and docile' (Szczepaniková, 2005, p.286).

The Gendering of Vulnerability and Community-Driven Aid Programmes

Having discussed the phenomena of renegotiated masculine and feminine subjectivities through the process of encampment, it is pertinent to analyse how vulnerability is gendered by NGOs. The gendering of vulnerability in encampment is primarily accomplished through the work of humanitarian aid programmes, whereby, often, men are ignored, and women are targeted, therefore positioning women as the primary vulnerable class within the refugee camp (Turner, 2019, p.602; Olivius, 2013, cited in Olivius, 2014, pp.98-99). Furthermore, NGOs sometimes fail to consider complex cultural and religious considerations within refugee camps' communities, precluding women from feeling comfortable enough to take part in the NGOs' provisions and spawning the organisation of community-driven aid. This is exemplified by the establishment of *taleems*[3] by Rohingya women refugees in Bangladesh, whereby feminine subjectivities are challenged by the reactions of refugee women to the work of NGOs within the refugee camp.

Taleems in Rohingya Refugee Camps: Community-Driven Aid as a Response to NGO Failures

The work of NGOs in refugee camps in Bangladesh became a feature of daily life for Rohingya refugees in encampment. In these camps, NGOs identified Rohingya women as being particularly 'susceptible to various forms of abuse or exploitation within the camp' (Rahman, 2019, p.878; Heltberg *et al.*, 2012, cited in Kabeer, 2015, p.200). Having identified that Rohingya women were, by their Western standards, targets of male subjugation, the NGOs

[3] A *taleem* is a space of education, emanating from the Arabic *taleem*, meaning 'education' or 'training'. In the Rohingya context, a *taleem* is a gender-segregated space where women recite the Qur'an and are educated on the meaning and significance of *Allah's* word.

began to focus their provisions on women, particularly by encouraging women's 'training through workshops and information dissemination' (Rahman, 2024, p.115; Madhok, 2013, p.122). For Rohingya refugees—both men and women—it became clear over time 'that much of the programming implemented by NGOs' was 'primarily geared towards women', leaving Rohingya men without the same humanitarian aid provisions afforded to their female counterparts (Rahman, 2024, p.115). Beyond directing humanitarian aid specifically at women, NGOs in refugee camps in Bangladesh 'set up a number of "women-friendly spaces" and "multi-purpose women's centres"', aiming to provide for Rohingya women 'a safe environment' for them to access those services provided by the NGOs (Rahman, 2019, p.878). Nevertheless, while NGOs framed their programming as empowering, their provisions were not universally welcomed, as they often clashed with Rohingya cultural norms.

While some Rohingya women alluded that NGOs 'provided opportunities that they were not afforded before in Myanmar' (Rahman, 2024, p.113), other Rohingya women 'remarked that NGOs had a tendency to introduce ideas that did not necessarily coincide well with Rohingya culture and conceptions of appropriate Islamic behaviour' (Rahman, 2024, p.121). These Rohingya women held that, while 'there was a need for more awareness of women's rights', 'traditional gendered roles' should not be collectively abandoned (Rahman, 2024, p.121). Rohingya men also held reservations about the work of NGOs in refugee camps in Bangladesh; one woman's father 'worried about the way NGOs were pushing for "rights" in a way that provided newfound freedoms that many feared were against the *izzot*[4] of women in Rohingya culture' (Rahman, 2024, p.119). Accordingly, while for some Rohingya women the work of NGOs allowed for a renegotiation of femininity, for other Rohingya women, as well as for many Rohingya men, the NGOs' programming was too radical and risked harm to a woman's *izzot*.

Consequently, some Rohingya women created spaces that offered alternative provisions to those from NGOs. One Rohingya woman, Zomila, created a *taleem* that could only be accessed by Rohingya women and their female guests. When discussing her thought process while founding her *taleem*, Zomila stated that she 'started [her] *taleem* because of…NGOs', and that NGOs were 'always involving themselves in [Rohingya's] business' (Zomila, quoted in Rahman, 2024, p.125). Continuing, she pointed out that nearly none of the NGOs came to the Rohingya's *taleem* to better understand the ways that Rohingya women 'do things according to' their 'culture and religion' (Zomila, quoted in Rahman, 2024, p.125). Like a majority of Rohingya refugees, Zomila believed that it was 'important to discuss things according to' Islam, and that the NGOs failed to connect with and to understand the religion and culture of Rohingya people, preferring to unilaterally decide what was best for Rohingya women (Zomila, quoted in Rahman, 2024, p.125). Zomila recognised the empowerment offered to women by the *taleem*, chastising the NGOs failure to recognise Rohingya women's agentic expression as empowerment (Zomila, quoted in Rahman, 2024, p.125). Though the process of encampment and interactions with NGOs challenged Rohingya's gendered subjectivities, Zomila's account exemplifies how refugees in encampment utilise their agency to negotiate gendered subjectivities on their own terms, ones that are coherent with their community's culture and religion. For instance, in the Rohingya refugee community, 'gender segregation' is practiced, with women 'relegated to spaces' where they are protected from men (Rahman, 2019, p.885; Coyle, Jainul and Petterson, 2020, p.19). As spaces 'exclusively for women', the *taleem* is seen as an appropriate space for women to attend by the Rohingya community at large, even as they serve as spaces for women's empowerment (Rahman, 2019, p.885). Rather than adopting

[4] *Izzot* signifies honour, dignity, prestige and personal and familial respect in Rohingya culture.

NGOs westernised feminine subjectivities, Zomila and others preferred to negotiate their feminine subjectivities aligned with religious and cultural observances, exercising their agency through collective Qur'anic recitations rather than through 'gender-violence workshops' (Rahman, 2024, p.115).

Time spent by Rohingya refugee women in a *taleem* is typically characterised by 'moments of collective *silence* and shared prayer (emphasis in original)', which highlight the women's 'unity and *strength* (emphasis in original)' creating for them 'a sense of belonging' (Rahman, 2019, p. 878; p.882). Rohingya women describe their presence at *taleems* 'meaningful and restorative', a place where they can 'cope and heal' together (Samson and Gifford, 2010, cited in Rahman, 2019, p.883). Aleya, one of Rahman's interlocutors from the Rohingya refugee community, said that 'sitting with the other women and hearing Allah's words…makes me feel safe…and that I feel I am part of a community' (Aleya, quoted in Rahman, 2019, p.881). Thus, the *taleem* serves a triple purpose for Rohingya refugee women. For some, the *taleem* offers a space to teach the words of the Qur'an, providing a community leadership opportunity in a context where such opportunities are limited. For others, the *taleem* provides a healing sense of community with other women in a place where community must be re-created (Sampson and Gifford, 2010, cited in Rahman, 2019, p.882; p.883). For others still, the *taleem* fills the gap in humanitarian aid provisions left by NGOs, one that addresses religious belief and the need for community-building that remains culturally conscious. In the *taleem*, women who are especially conscious of their *izzot* enact their agency through community building, religious scholarship and collective healing. It is in the context of encampment, further influenced by NGO provisions, that Rohingya women's conceptualisations of femininity are renegotiated; by engaging with new roles and activities, the very meaning of femininity for Rohingya refugee women is altered, all while retaining Rohingya men's 'masculinity and gender identity' (Rahman, 2024, p.119).

Conclusion

In this paper, I provided concrete examples of changing gendered subjectivities within refugee camps. For refugees — be they Burundian, Chechen or Rohingya — the experience of encampment provides the opportunity to renegotiate the very meanings of and roles ascribed to masculinity and femininity. As was the case in the Burundian ethnography, interactions with new cultures through the physical location of and those within the refugee camp provide new examples for behaviour that change the way refugees perceive gendered subjectivities. In other cases, the harsh constraints within the refugee camp act as agents of change upon conceptualisations of gender, as exemplified by the Chechen refugee camp in the Czech Republic. Further, the story of Rohingya *taleems* narrates how responses to outside actors within refugee camps can themselves be drivers of change for gendered subjectivities.

I do not seek to claim that these three narratives fully encapsulate the ways in which gendered subjectivities change through refugee encampment. These narratives only represent three ways of many that evince the power that refugee camps have to change perceptions, conceptualisations and performances of gender for refugees. Future research should devote itself to expanding the scholarship on the ways refugee camps create opportunities for gender renegotiation.

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